



**Indian Institute of Technology Madras
Zanzibar Campus**

SUBJECT: DIGITAL LIVES

Social Media and Politics in Tamil Nadu

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January 2026

Abstract

Social media platforms are now an important part of political communication. However, how platform algorithms influence regional political discussions is still not fully understood. This study examines political content shared on Instagram and YouTube in Tamil Nadu, India. It focuses on the types of political content, how people respond to them, and how algorithms increase the visibility of certain content.

A curated dataset of political posts and videos was analyzed using normalized engagement measures and a relative amplification index. The results show that emotional, meme-based, and satirical political content receives much higher visibility than formal political messages. Although this study does not directly link social media activity to voting behavior, it clearly shows that algorithms strongly shape what political content people see. This has important implications for political discussion and future elections in Tamil Nadu.

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1 Introduction

Social media platforms have changed the way political communication happens by allowing direct interaction between political leaders and the public. In India, especially in Tamil Nadu, platforms such as Instagram and YouTube are widely used for sharing political messages, discussions, and opinions. Unlike traditional media, these platforms depend on algorithms that decide which content is shown to users based on engagement such as likes, comments, and views.

This study explores how political content is shared on Instagram and YouTube in Tamil Nadu, how people interact with different types of political content, and how algorithms affect content visibility. The aim is to understand how these processes influence political communication and public discussion, especially during election periods.

2 Objectives

The main objectives of this study are:

- To identify different types of political content shared on Instagram and YouTube.
- To study how people engage with political posts and videos.
- To examine how platform algorithms amplify certain types of political content.
- To understand the effect of algorithm-driven visibility on political communication in Tamil Nadu.

3 Data Collection

3.1 Platforms

This study focuses on two popular social media platforms:

- Instagram
- YouTube

3.2 Data Scope

Only publicly available political content was collected. The dataset includes posts and videos related to political parties, leaders, speeches, news reports, commentary, memes, emotional messages, and satirical content. The data was collected over a three-month period.

3.3 Ethical Considerations

No private user information was collected in this study. Individual users were not identified, and all data used is publicly accessible. The study follows ethical guidelines for academic research.

4 Methodology

4.1 Content Typology

Political content was grouped into predefined categories such as official political messages, speech clips, emotional content, memes, troll or satirical content, news reports, commentary, and analysis. A rule-based classification method was used to ensure clarity and consistency.

4.2 Engagement Metrics

To compare engagement fairly across platforms, the following normalized measures were used:

Instagram:

$$Engagement\ Rate = \frac{Likes + Comments}{Followers}$$

YouTube:

$$Comment\ Intensity = \frac{Comments}{Views}$$

4.3 Algorithmic Amplification Index

Since platform algorithms are not publicly visible, algorithmic influence was estimated using a relative measure:

$$Amplification\ Index = \frac{Average\ Content\ Engagement}{Platform\ Median\ Engagement}$$

Values greater than one indicate higher-than-average visibility, while values less than one indicate lower visibility.

5 Results

5.1 Content Typology Distribution

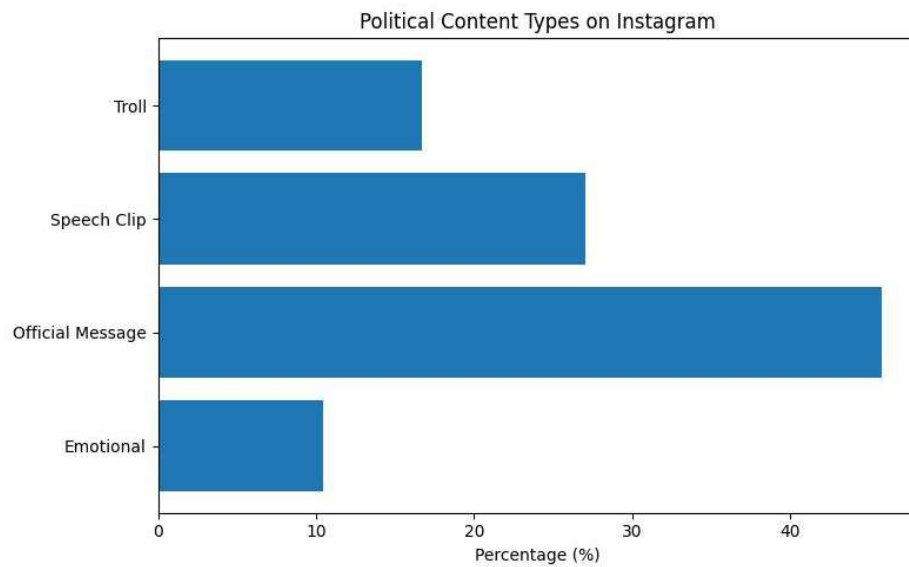


Figure 1: Political Content Types on Instagram

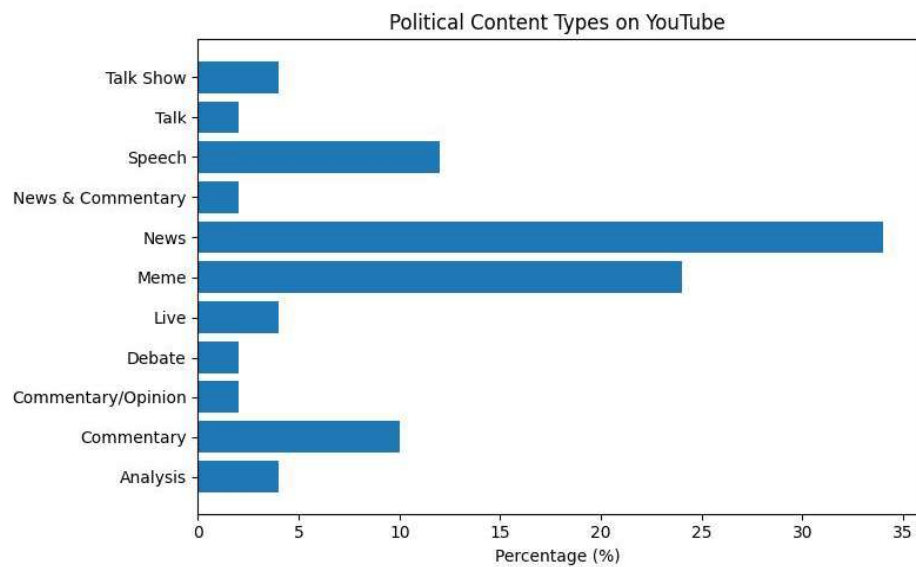


Figure 2: Political Content Types on YouTube

Instagram content mainly consists of official political messages, while YouTube shows a wider variety of content, including news, memes, and political commentary.

5.2 Public Engagement Analysis

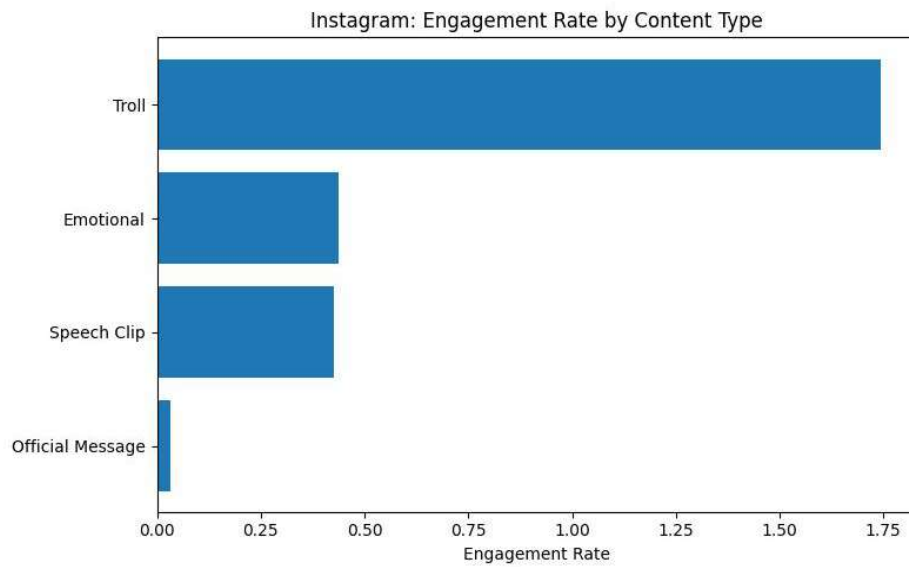


Figure 3: Instagram Engagement Rate by Content Type

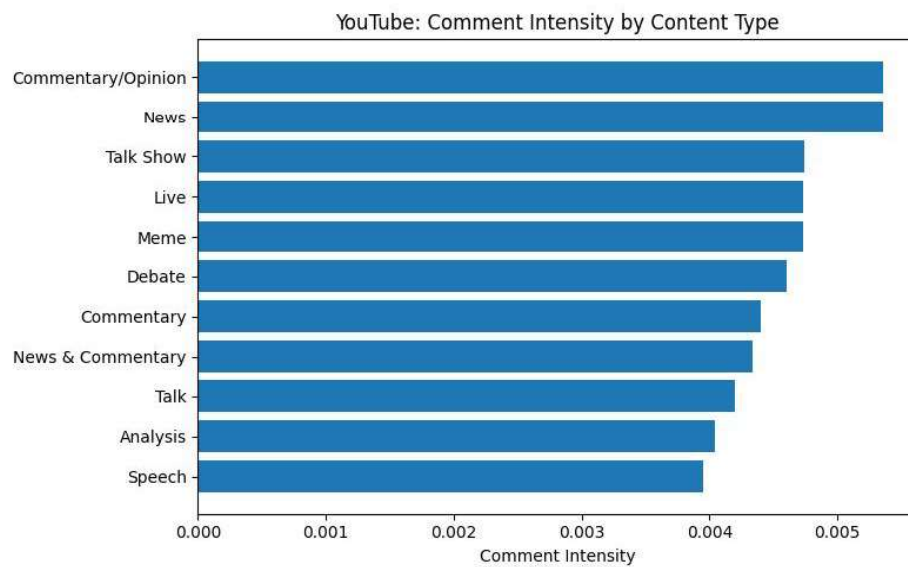


Figure 4: YouTube Comment Intensity by Content Type

The engagement analysis shows that troll, emotional, and meme-based political content receives much higher engagement than official political messages.

5.3 Algorithmic Amplification Patterns

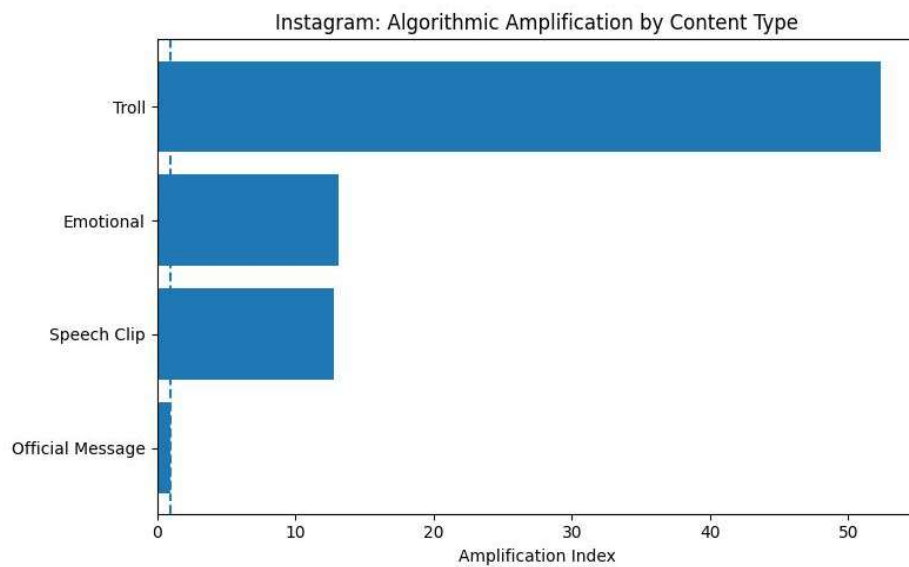


Figure 5: Instagram Algorithmic Amplification by Content Type

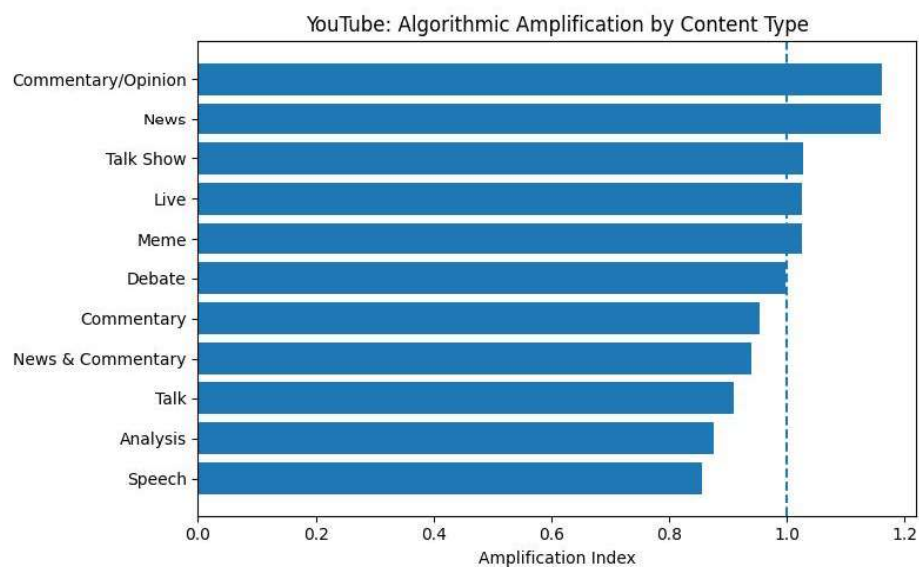


Figure 6: YouTube Algorithmic Amplification by Content Type

The amplification analysis shows that troll content is strongly amplified on Instagram, while commentary-based political content receives greater visibility on YouTube.

6 Discussion

The results show that social media platforms do not treat all political content equally. Content that attracts more user interaction, especially emotional and satirical content, is given more visibility by platform algorithms. This affects how political messages are presented and how people understand political issues online.

7 Implications for Tamil Nadu Elections

Although this study does not directly measure voting behavior, the findings suggest that algorithms influence which political messages receive more attention. By promoting certain types of content, social media platforms may indirectly shape political opinions and discussions during elections.

8 Limitations

This study estimates algorithmic behavior using engagement data and does not have direct access to platform recommendation systems. In addition, individual voting behavior and election results were not analyzed.

9 Conclusion

This study shows that social media platforms play an important role in shaping political communication in Tamil Nadu. Algorithms tend to promote emotional and informal political content more than formal messages. While social media activity cannot be directly linked to election results, these platforms clearly influence what political content people see and discuss.

References

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